

TO The Alberta Law Foundation · Program & Operating
Grants

PREPARED BY IslamicFamily

DATE August
2026

Community Justice Architecture

Making legal support accessible & cost-effective

Unlocking pro bono and low-bono legal capacity for Alberta communities, and giving community philanthropy a transparent, accountable channel to fund it.

THE CORE IDEA

Between the legal-aid cutoff and the cost of a private lawyer sits a large group of Albertans with real legal problems and no real options. Their communities already contain qualified lawyers willing to help, and already practise generous, organized charitable giving. What is missing is the infrastructure that connects vetted legal capacity to the people who need it, and channels community philanthropy to pay for it transparently. A focused, Foundation-funded pilot builds that infrastructure once, and it pays for itself in reduced demand on Legal Aid, the courts, and downstream social services.

MISSION ALIGNMENT

This delivers on the Foundation's own objects

This proposal maps directly onto the Alberta Law Foundation's mission: to advance access to justice by supporting collaboration and innovation in the delivery of legal services and the administration of justice in Alberta. Community Amplified Legal Supports is a community-led, sustainable way to advance several of the Foundation's funding objects at once, with priority given, as the Foundation directs, to Albertans facing vulnerabilities and barriers.

Foundation object: provide legal information and education so Albertans understand their rights and obligations, and what they can expect from the justice system.

This is CALS on one side of the ledger: multilingual public legal education and "know your rights" literacy, delivered where communities actually gather.

Foundation object: provide direct services, such as legal advice or representation, in response to genuine need, with a focus on individuals facing vulnerabilities.

This is the other side: warm connection to vetted, qualified counsel, with a philanthropic fund covering the affordability gap so that advice actually reaches the client.

Foundation priority: organizations serving individuals facing barriers, with the cultural competency, trauma-informed care, and newcomer focus reflected in the Foundation's own granting.

CALS is built for exactly the barrier-compounded Albertan: language, literacy, disability, newcomer status, or distrust. Its navigator model shares the justice-navigation ethos the Foundation is already investing in.

Foundation strategic goal: invest in sustainable, effective initiatives with demonstrable impact, and build sector capacity as a convener.

CALS pairs a one-time build with a community-philanthropy engine that sustains the help after the grant ends, and it convenes the bar's latent pro bono capacity into an organized, accountable service.

Foundation object: undertake research that helps the law and the administration of justice evolve to meet Albertans' needs.

A core Year 1 deliverable is an audited evidence base, so CALS is not only a service but a documented, replicable model that other Alberta communities can adopt.

THE PROBLEM

The problem is bigger than a funding gap

It is tempting to describe this as a thin "missing middle" of people who earn just too much for legal aid. The reality is broader. Across the whole low-to-middle income range, Albertans cannot reliably access legal help. Legal Aid Alberta is stretched, its expenses nearly doubling in a decade from roughly \$72 million in 2014 to over \$138 million in 2024, and it is concentrated by design on criminal, child-protection, and some family and immigration matters, which leaves most everyday civil problems uncovered even for many who qualify. Just above the eligibility line, people have no funded option at all, against private fees that run to hundreds of dollars an hour. This is an access failure across a wide band of the population, not a narrow slice.

And it compounds. Add any barrier, a first language other than English, limited literacy, a disability, unfamiliarity with Canadian systems, or distrust earned from a bad experience, and the difficulty does not simply add up, it multiplies. National research by the Canadian Forum on Civil Justice found that within any three-year period, roughly half of Canadian adults, about 11.4 million people, experience a serious civil or family legal problem, and that the average person who spends money trying to resolve one spends about \$6,100. Federal Department of Justice research found that for most immigrant participants, simple lack of information was the main barrier. The people who most need help are the ones for whom the system is least navigable, and that is exactly where predatory actors move in.

Meanwhile, communities are already trying to fill the gap themselves. When a neighbour faces a costly legal fight, families quietly pool money to help. This community-sponsored aid is generous, but it operates in the wilderness, with no structure, no vetting of who gets hired, no oversight of the funds, and no record of what the case recovered. It is goodwill without scaffolding, and it is invisible to the system that could learn from it.

ACCESS, NOT JUST AFFORDABILITY

Across low-to-middle incomes, legal help is out of reach. Legal aid is stretched and narrow in scope; just above the line, there is no funded option at all.

BARRIERS COMPOUND

Language, literacy, disability, newcomer status, or distrust do not just add difficulty, they multiply it. The greatest need sits where the system is least navigable.

COMMUNITY AID IN THE WILDERNESS

Communities already pool money to help, but with no structure, vetting, or oversight. Generosity without accountability, and invisible to the system.

Unresolved legal problems do not disappear when people cannot afford a lawyer or cannot navigate the system. They migrate downstream into lost jobs, housing instability, family breakdown, and ill health, where the public pays for them anyway, at far higher cost. The cheapest moment to resolve a legal problem is the earliest one.

THE PROPOSAL

Community Amplified Legal Supports (CALS)

CALS is a trusted-intermediary service that does four things the current system does not do well. It connects low-to-middle income Albertans, and especially those facing added barriers, to vetted, qualified legal professionals who speak their language and understand their values. It subsidizes affordable low-bono fees through a transparent community-philanthropy fund. It protects people from predatory and unlicensed advisors, and brings oversight to community giving that currently has none. And, carefully and over time, it develops culturally grounded dispute-resolution pathways that keep suitable matters out of court entirely.

It is built on infrastructure that already exists. IslamicFamily already runs legal education and legal clinics, already serves more than 10,000 clients a year in over ten languages, and already operates a trusted, transparent system for directing charitable giving to people in need. CALS does not invent these capacities. It points them, deliberately, at the access-to-justice gap.

01

Connect

A vetted roster of qualified lawyers and licensed professionals, matched to clients by language, culture, and values, so help actually lands. Warm referral and follow-through, not a phone number on a website.

02

Subsidize

A transparent Legal Supports Fund pays the gap between a reduced low-bono fee and what a vetted client can afford. It extends affordable advice above the legal-aid line, where no public funding currently reaches.

03

Protect & Educate

Multilingual public legal education, plus oversight of community giving. Albertans already donate to help with each other's legal cases, often with no record of where the money goes, what the lawyer charged, or how the settlement turned out. CALS gives that generosity transparency and accountability, and steers people away from ghost consultants before harm is done.

04

Resolve

A phased, consultative dispute-resolution track, modelled on our counselling services, that is faith-grounded but delivered by licensed professionals fully within Alberta's legal framework.

The pitch to the Foundation is not "fund a service." It is this: invest once in the connective infrastructure, and unlock two forms of capacity already sitting idle: the goodwill of community lawyers, and the organized generosity of community donors.

TRACK RECORD

Why IslamicFamily is the right anchor for this

CALS is not a standing start. For more than three decades, IslamicFamily has been a load-bearing piece of Edmonton's social infrastructure, the organization that shows up when the formal system cannot or will not reach. In the legal-empowerment space specifically, the foundations are already laid.

WHAT WE ALREADY DO

An existing base of legal-empowerment work

- ✳ **Legal education and workshops.** IslamicFamily has hosted legal information sessions and clinics for years, delivered in the languages and settings where its communities actually gather, in partnership with the Alberta Law Foundation and legal volunteers
- ✳ **Recognized for justice innovation.** Recipient of a Government of Alberta Justice award for innovation in community justice delivery, alongside broader provincial recognition for community impact
- ✳ **Imagine Canada accredited.** Meeting national standards for governance, financial accountability, and transparency, the prerequisite for holding and disbursing restricted charitable funds responsibly
- ✳ **Trusted, multilingual reach.** More than 10,000 clients served annually, services delivered in over ten languages, by practitioners who in many cases share the cultural and faith background of the people they serve

This matters because the hardest problem any new legal service faces is the first one: getting people through the door. Trust is not transferable and cannot be bought. It is earned slowly, and IslamicFamily has already earned it. Attaching legal supports to that existing trust shortens the adoption curve from years to weeks, and gives both the lawyer and the client a credible institution standing behind the relationship.

THE MODEL

How CALS works in practice

CALS is a switchboard with quality control on both sides. It vets the legal professionals who join the roster, and it vets the clients and matters that come in, confirming that the need is genuine, appropriately scoped, and a fit for pro bono or subsidized low-bono support rather than a fee-generating case better served privately.

THE PATHWAY

From first contact to resolution

- ✳ **Intake and triage.** A multilingual navigator identifies the legal issue, screens financial eligibility on a sliding scale, and flags urgency and risk, including signs that someone has already been targeted by an unlicensed advisor
- ✳ **Matching.** The client is matched to a vetted lawyer by area of law and, wherever possible, by shared language and cultural context, with a warm handoff rather than a cold referral
- ✳ **Pro bono or low-bono.** Straightforward matters are handled pro bono. Where a fuller engagement is needed, the lawyer charges a reduced rate and the Legal Supports Fund pays the affordability gap
- ✳ **Follow-through and education.** The navigator holds the relationship to completion, and every interaction doubles as legal literacy the client carries forward

WHERE THE NEED IS GREATEST

CALS focuses on the everyday civil and family matters that fall through the existing net: employment and unpaid wages, tenancy and eviction, family separation and custody, immigration and sponsorship, small-business and entrepreneurship law, and wills, estates, and notarial services, which are disproportionately absent in newcomer and lower-income households. Federal Department of Justice research has found that for the large majority of immigrant participants, simple lack of information was the main reason they could not find legal help or did not pursue it at all. CALS is built for exactly that person.

A PROPER CHANNEL FOR CIVIL-LIBERTIES AND RIGHTS MATTERS

Some of the most consequential problems people bring are not everyday civil disputes but rights matters: discrimination, religious freedom and accommodation, hate-motivated harm, and privacy violations. These are exactly the cases that go unaddressed today, because people do not know whether they have a claim or where it belongs, and meritorious matters never reach the right venue. CALS gives them a trusted channel. It identifies and triages these matters and routes them to the proper destination, whether a human-rights complaint, specialist or public-interest counsel, or an appropriate clinic or organization. CALS channels and connects rather than conducting impact litigation itself, so this adds reach for communities that are too often on the receiving end of rights violations, without adding litigation cost.

Pro bono and low-bono are complements to legal aid, not substitutes for it. Every credible program in this field, from Pro Bono Law Alberta to the UK's LawWorks, is careful to make that point. CALS is designed to relieve pressure on legal aid by resolving matters upstream, not to replace a properly funded public system.

The community philanthropy engine, built on giving that already happens

The distinctive feature of CALS is how the legal help gets paid for. IslamicFamily already operates a trusted, accountable system for directing community charitable giving, zakat and sadaqa, to community members in need. These are not ad hoc collections. They are structured forms of giving with their own requirements for eligible recipients and transparent administration, practised faithfully across the community. CALS extends that existing engine to a new purpose: legal need.

THE LEGAL SUPPORTS FUND

How a donor's gift reaches a family in need

- ✳ **Give.** Community members and institutions contribute to a restricted Legal Supports Fund held within IslamicFamily, with charitable tax receipts and full reporting
- ✳ **Direct (optional).** Donors may restrict gifts to a particular community or legal area, the way a named or advised fund works, while administration remains independent and rules-based
- ✳ **Subsidize.** The fund pays the gap on low-bono matters and underwrites clinic operations, so a family pays what it can and the fund covers the rest
- ✳ **Account.** Every dollar in and out is reported, satisfying both charitable-law requirements and the transparency that faith-based giving traditions themselves demand

This design draws on giving traditions common across many of Alberta's faith and cultural communities, including zakat and sadaqa, tithing, and dāna, and turns diffuse generosity into a reliable, auditable stream of legal support. It is built to extend coverage beyond what legal aid reaches, not to duplicate it. The fund deliberately serves low-to-middle income Albertans, those facing added barriers, and the matter types that public funding does not cover.

It also fixes a real accountability gap. Today, when a community member faces a costly legal fight, families quietly pool money to help, sometimes substantial sums, with no record of how much was raised, how it was spent, what the lawyer charged, or what the case recovered. Routing that generosity through the Legal Supports Fund replaces good intentions with an audit trail, protects donors and recipients alike, and keeps the giving from fracturing the relationships it was meant to strengthen.

For the Foundation, this is the leverage. The grant is not the whole cost of the help. It is the scaffolding that makes community philanthropy flow reliably into legal supports. Every Foundation dollar is multiplied by community dollars that would otherwise never reach a courtroom or a clinic.

Culturally grounded dispute resolution, on a framework that already exists

The need is established, and so is the legal framework. Alberta's Arbitration Act, together with well-established family and commercial arbitration practice in the province, already lets parties resolve civil and commercial disputes out of court, with awards enforceable through and reviewable by the courts. CALS does not need new legislation. It needs trained, accredited, culturally and linguistically competent practitioners working within the law already on the books. The task is delivery, not study.

Other jurisdictions show both that this works and where the guardrails belong. In British Columbia, family-law arbitrators are accredited by the Law Society, must meet minimum training and practice standards, and cannot opt out of the law: every decision must be consistent with the Family Law Act (Province of British Columbia). In the United Kingdom, faith-informed arbitration of civil and commercial matters operates under the Arbitration Act 1996, enforceable in court where both parties agree and the law is followed. And the Canadian experience, especially Ontario's reforms, sets the bright lines: family arbitration must apply Canadian law only, there is no parallel religious jurisdiction, criminal and divorce matters are off the table, and protection for women and vulnerable parties is non-negotiable.

CALS adopts those guardrails as design features, not caveats. Mediation and arbitration here are faith-informed in sensibility but Canadian-law in substance, conducted by accredited, licensed professionals to provincial standards, with independent legal advice for each party, domestic-violence and power-imbalance screening built into intake, and full rights of review and appeal. This is the counselling-services model applied to disputes: culturally attuned and professionally accountable, with no parallel system.

SEQUENCED, AND STARTING NOW

Year 1 puts the people and frameworks in place

- ✳ **Hiring and frameworks (Year 1).** Recruit and train accredited, culturally and linguistically competent mediators and arbitrators who meet Law Society and provincial standards, and put the screening, standards, and intake protocols in place, with domestic-violence and power-imbalance safeguards built in from the start
- ✳ **Community legal education (Year 1).** Rights-first education so people understand their options, the limits of any out-of-court process, and how to avoid coercive or unlicensed informal forums
- ✳ **Limited, supervised piloting (Year 2 onward).** Once the frameworks and trained capacity are in place, begin with the cleanest matters, commercial and civil disputes and family mediation with independent legal advice, scaling only as evaluated outcomes justify

We are not asking permission to study a need that is already proven. In Year 1 we put the people and frameworks in place and educate the community, and we begin to pilot carefully once those foundations are set, all within Alberta's existing legal framework, with fairness and the protection of vulnerable parties as the first test rather than an afterthought.

A CONCRETE PUBLIC-PROTECTION WIN

Reducing the harm of predatory and unlicensed advisors

Where trustworthy legal help is unaffordable, a market of predatory actors fills the vacuum, nowhere more visibly than in immigration. The harm is real, documented, and local. In 2024, an unauthorized Edmonton-area immigration consultant was convicted of charging for services she was not licensed to provide, including fake job offers and forged documents, and was ordered to pay \$148,000 in victim restitution (Canada Border Services Agency). Between 2019 and 2024, the CBSA charged more than 150 individuals nationally with immigration-consultant-related fraud.

The regulatory system has a structural blind spot that CALS is positioned to address. New federal rules taking effect in 2026 create a compensation fund for victims of dishonest licensed consultants, but that fund explicitly does not cover losses caused by unlicensed "ghost" consultants, who cause much of the most serious harm (Government of Canada). Enforcement reaches these actors only after the money is gone, and the immigration file is often already jeopardized.

CALS works upstream of all of this. The most effective protection against a ghost consultant is the early availability of a trustworthy, affordable, community-rooted alternative, together with the multilingual public legal education that helps people recognize a scam before they pay for it. This is harm prevention, delivered by the institutions communities already trust.

ENVIRONMENTAL SCAN

This model is proven: Alberta would be assembling known parts in a new way

CALS is not speculative. Each of its components has an established analogue in Canada, the United States, or the United Kingdom. What is novel is the combination of a community-trusted intermediary, language-and-values matching, and a philanthropic subsidy engine, brought together in a single Alberta service.

CANADA · COORDINATION

Pro Bono Law Alberta and Access Pro Bono BC

Pro Bono Law Alberta, a charitable legacy project of the Law Society, promotes and coordinates pro bono work and brokers partnerships, but by design does not deliver services to the public directly. That leaves the community-facing, language-matched delivery layer open. CALS fills it, and partners with the coordination bodies rather than duplicating them.

UNITED STATES · THE SUBSIDY MECHANIC

"Modest means" and low-bono panels

Bar associations and legal-aid bodies across the US run reduced-fee panels for people above the pro bono cutoff but unable to pay full rates, typically with sliding-scale fees (often in the range of \$35 to \$80 an hour) and eligibility around 250% of the poverty line. Low-bono is formally recognized in the American Bar Association's Model Rule 6.1 as legitimate public service. CALS adapts this mechanic, adding a philanthropic fund to cover the client's share.

UNITED KINGDOM · CLINIC NETWORK AT SCALE

LawWorks and Advocate

LawWorks, the solicitors' national pro bono charity, supports a network of more than 300 independent legal clinics that handled roughly 70,000 enquiries in a single recent year. Advocate, the Bar's charity, matches barristers to people who cannot get legal aid and cannot afford to pay. Both are explicit that pro bono complements and never replaces legal aid, the framing CALS adopts directly.

The lesson from all three jurisdictions is consistent: volunteer and reduced-fee legal capacity is abundant, but it only reaches people when a trusted intermediary organizes it. CALS is that intermediary, with the added Alberta innovation of a community-philanthropy engine to pay for the subsidized share.

THE BUSINESS CASE

What this looks like for real people, and the public purse

The following are illustrative composites, drawn from the kinds of matters IslamicFamily already encounters, not real individuals. Each traces the same logic: an early, affordable, trusted intervention prevents a far costlier downstream outcome.

CASE A · EMPLOYMENT

The unpaid wages that became a rent-assistance claim

A newcomer takes a framing job with a small contractor. After six weeks he is let go with about \$4,200 in wages unpaid and his final cheque returned NSF. He earns just above the Legal Aid Alberta eligibility line, so he does not qualify. The two private lawyers he calls want a retainer larger than the wages he is owed, and neither speaks his language. He does not know that Alberta's employment-standards complaint process is free to file and needs no lawyer at all. Discouraged and now behind on rent, he gives up, borrows from family, and within two months is relying on rent assistance while he looks for work.

With CALS: intake flags a strong, low-cost claim. A vetted lawyer who shares his language advises him pro bono on filing the employment-standards complaint and drafts the demand letter, with the Fund covering a few hours of follow-up. The wages are recovered in weeks. No rent arrears, no rent-assistance claim, no eviction filing. The public cost is avoided, and a worker is kept housed and employed.

CASE B · IMMIGRATION

The ghost consultant, intercepted before the harm

A woman wants to sponsor her husband. A man advertising in a community group quotes \$9,000 for a "guaranteed fast" spousal sponsorship and offers to supply a supporting employment letter "to make the file stronger." He is unlicensed, the letter is fabricated, and if she submits it she risks not only losing the money but a finding of misrepresentation that can carry a multi-year bar from re-applying. She has no easy way to tell a legitimate representative from a fraudulent one.

With CALS: a community legal-literacy session, delivered in her language, teaches her to check any representative against the public licensing register, and she recognizes the warning signs. The navigator confirms the consultant is unlicensed and matches her to a licensed immigration lawyer who handles the sponsorship honestly at a subsidized rate. A \$9,000 loss and a jeopardized immigration future are both prevented, and a fraudster loses a customer.

CASE C · COMMUNITY-FUNDED CASE

Generosity that finally has an audit trail

When a respected community member faces a costly legal fight, word spreads and families quietly contribute, sometimes tens of thousands of dollars, to help cover legal fees. It is generous and well-meant. It is also completely unaccountable. There is no record of how much was raised, how it was spent, what the lawyer charged, or what the case ultimately recovered. Donors never learn the outcome, and disputes over leftover funds or the settlement can fracture the very relationships the giving was meant to strengthen.

With CALS: the same generosity flows through the restricted Legal Supports Fund. Contributions are receipted, the engagement and the lawyer's reduced fee are documented, disbursements are recorded, and donors receive clean reporting on how their giving was used. Charitable generosity keeps its spirit and gains accountability, and the community's trust is protected rather than put at risk.

CASE D · FAMILY AND SMALL BUSINESS

The dispute that never needed a courtroom

Two relatives who built a small business together are falling out. Left alone, this becomes parallel court actions, a partnership dissolution alongside a family-law thread, months of delay, and, if either qualifies, a Legal Aid certificate plus dozens of hours of court and chambers time. The relationship, and likely the business and the jobs it supports, will not survive the process.

With CALS (Year 2 onward): the matter is screened as suitable for the supervised, lawful mediation pilot. A licensed mediator, working within Alberta's Arbitration Act and with independent legal advice available to each party, resolves the split over a small number of sessions. The court file is never opened, the business is sold as a going concern rather than collapsed, and the jobs are preserved.

SYSTEM VALUE

The fiscal case: conservative, and it still clears the bar

The strongest argument for CALS is that early legal help is cheaper than the alternatives the public pays for anyway. We can put a defensible, conservative number on it using Legal Aid Alberta's own figures.

Legal Aid Alberta's own duty-counsel triage program offers a clean Alberta anchor. It resolves roughly 1,000 low-level matters a year, saving about \$1.6 million in certificate costs. That works out to roughly \$1,600 in avoided certificate cost per matter diverted, before counting court time at all. The Canadian Bar Association has estimated that a single contested matter can consume up to 60 hours of court time (2013). And nationally, the Canadian Forum on Civil Justice

estimates that unresolved everyday legal problems cost the state about \$799 million a year in added social-assistance (\$248M), employment-insurance (\$450M), and health-care (\$101M) spending.

THE BREAK-EVEN LINE

Using Legal Aid Alberta's own figure of roughly \$1,600 in certificate-cost saving per diverted matter, the entire \$300,000 annual grant is returned if CALS diverts just:

~188 matters per year

That is the break-even in avoided certificate costs alone, roughly three or four matters a week. It counts none of the court-time savings, none of the downstream social-assistance, EI, and health-care costs avoided, and none of the community philanthropy the Fund channels on top. Those are all additional return.

A mature CALS handling several hundred advice interactions a year, of which a conservative subset genuinely divert a certificate or court matter, comfortably exceeds break-even. The table below sketches an illustrative annual value at modest scale.

CONSERVATIVE ANNUAL VALUE (ILLUSTRATIVE)	BASIS	EST. VALUE
Matters diverted from a Legal Aid certificate or court stream	250 × ~\$1,600	\$400,000
Court-time savings on diverted contested matters	subset of above	\$120,000+
Downstream social-assistance, EI, and health costs avoided	share of \$799M/yr	\$150,000+
Predatory-advisor losses prevented for clients	illustrative	\$100,000+
Indicative annual public and community value		\$770,000+
Against an annual grant of		\$300,000

Figures are illustrative and deliberately conservative, intended to frame order-of-magnitude return rather than forecast precise savings. Sources: Legal Aid Alberta (certificate cost per diverted matter, expense trend); Canadian Bar Association, 2013 (court time per contested matter); Canadian Forum on Civil Justice (downstream state costs of unresolved legal problems); Canada Border Services Agency (immigration-fraud restitution). A core deliverable of Year 1 is to replace these estimates with measured, audited program data.

This is upstream investment at exactly the right point in the system. Every matter resolved at the advice, clinic, or mediation stage is a Legal Aid certificate not issued, court hours not consumed, and downstream social-services demand not triggered, at a fraction of the cost of intervening after the fact.

A high-level three-year plan

The pilot runs six parallel workstreams. Year 1 builds and launches, Year 2 scales and pilots, and Year 3 proves the model and prepares it to travel to other Alberta communities. Each workstream carries its own milestones and is measured against them.

WORKSTREAM	YEAR 1 · BUILD	YEAR 2 · SCALE	YEAR 3 · PROVE
Service and roster	Hire team, recruit and vet the roster, launch intake, triage, matching, and clinics	Expand roster and clinic hours, add matter types, raise volume	Steady-state operations with a documented delivery playbook
Legal Supports Fund	Establish the restricted fund, receipting, disbursement and reporting rules, first subsidized matters	Grow donor base and philanthropy match, publish first transparency report	Fund covers the majority of the subsidy, annual public reporting
Education and anti-fraud	Multilingual workshops and a "check the licence" campaign through community channels	Broaden reach across communities, measure scam recognition	Embed as an ongoing program with train-the-trainer capacity
Dispute resolution (ADR)	ADR rights education, recruit and train accredited mediators, put screening, standards, and protocols in place	Launch limited supervised piloting of commercial and civil matters, add family mediation with independent legal advice	Evaluate outcomes and fairness, decide on continuation and expansion
Civil-liberties channel	Build referral pathways with human-rights bodies and specialist counsel, set the triage protocol	Active channeling, track where matters land and how they resolve	Formalize the referral network and report on outcomes
Evaluation and templating	Baseline metrics, data system, and logic model	Mid-point evaluation and audited savings data	Independent evaluation and a replication playbook for Calgary, Red Deer, and Lethbridge

\$300,000 per year for three years: what it buys

The request is for \$300,000 annually over a three-year pilot, \$900,000 in total, to build and prove the CALS model in Edmonton with a design that is explicitly portable to other Alberta communities. The lean structure reflects the core principle: grant dollars build infrastructure and seed the subsidy pool, while community philanthropy and donated professional time supply the bulk of the legal capacity.

LINE ITEM	WHAT IT COVERS	ANNUAL
PEOPLE		
Program Director / Legal Navigator Lead	Roster development and vetting, partnerships, fund administration, reporting, supervision (up to 1.0 FTE)	\$95,000
Bilingual Intake and Client Navigator	Triage, eligibility screening, matching, predatory-advisor screening, follow-through (1.0 FTE)	\$62,000
DIRECT LEGAL SUPPORT		
Low-Bono Subsidy Pool (grant share)	Pays the affordability gap on subsidized matters, matched and topped up by the community Legal Supports Fund	\$60,000
Roster honoraria and clinic delivery	Drop-in clinic costs and modest stipends for clinic hours beyond donated pro bono time	\$25,000
EDUCATION, PROTECTION, AND DEVELOPMENT		
Multilingual public legal education	Workshops, translated materials, community-channel distribution, anti-fraud campaigns	\$22,000
Dispute resolution: education, training, piloting	ADR rights education, training of accredited mediators, and limited supervised piloting within Alberta's framework	\$12,000
SYSTEMS AND ACCOUNTABILITY		
Evaluation and impact reporting	Outcome measurement and the audited evidence base for continued investment	\$9,000
Technology and intake systems	Secure intake, case tracking, fund-disbursement records	\$5,000
Administration and overhead (~3.3%)	Finance, insurance, audit, facilities allocation	\$10,000
Total annual request		\$300,000
Total three-year pilot		\$900,000

The annual total holds steady at \$300,000, but the mix shifts: Year 1 weights toward people, roster development, training, and education; Year 2 shifts toward the subsidy pool as matter volume and the philanthropy match grow; Year 3 weights toward evaluation and the work of making the model portable to other Alberta communities. The full milestone view is set out in the Work Plan above.

Who is at the table

CALS is anchored and operated by IslamicFamily. Around it we are convening a coalition of legal organizations and practitioners, both current and prospective, who bring professional capacity, cultural and linguistic competency, and standing in the bar. The partnership combines a trusted community institution with the legal expertise to deliver at a professional standard. Final partner commitments will be confirmed as the pilot is scoped with the Foundation.

IslamicFamily

ANCHOR & LEAD OPERATOR

More than 30 years of community service. Imagine Canada accredited. Recognized with a Government of Alberta Justice award for innovation in community justice delivery. Operator of the intake, clinics, navigator team, and the Legal Supports Fund. 10,000+ clients served annually in over ten languages.

South Asian Bar Association Edmonton

LEGAL DELIVERY PARTNER

Legal professionals with cultural and linguistic competency across the communities CALS serves. Workshop delivery, pro bono and low-bono clinic hours, and access to a wider legal network.

Canadian Muslim Lawyers Association (CMLA)

LEGAL DELIVERY PARTNER

A national network of Muslim legal professionals with deep community trust and cultural competency, extending the program's reach and credibility across Alberta.

This coalition, a community anchor joined by specialist legal organizations and committed practitioners, is the right group to deliver at scale. Provincial investment is the catalyst that moves it from coalition to program.

Where this fits the access-to-justice agenda



Access to justice, delivered upstream. CALS is direct delivery of Alberta's access-to-justice goals for underserved Albertans. It is preventive, community-anchored, and designed to relieve pressure on Legal Aid Alberta rather than compete with it.



Fiscal responsibility and leverage. A focused pilot that pays for itself in avoided system costs, and multiplies every granted dollar with community philanthropy. The Foundation builds the scaffolding once, and the community keeps funding the help.



Consumer protection. A concrete, measurable reduction in the harm done by predatory and unlicensed advisors, filling the gap that even the new federal compensation fund leaves open for ghost consultants.



Civil-society activation. Alberta's bar holds significant pro bono and low-bono goodwill that goes underused for lack of infrastructure to deploy it. CALS turns that latent capacity into organized, accountable community benefit.

THE ASK

What we are asking of the Foundation

A single, focused investment: the funding to build and prove a three-year pilot.

THE ASK

\$300,000 per year, for three years

A Program and Operating Grant to build and prove Community Amplified Legal Supports in Edmonton, designed to scale to other Alberta communities.

The lawyers willing to help are here. The community generosity to pay for it is here. The trusted institution to connect them is here. What is missing is the scaffolding, and a small, focused pilot builds it once, then lets community capacity carry it forward.

ISLAMICFAMILY

10,000+

Clients served annually across all programs

30+

Years serving Edmonton's newcomer, faith, and cultural communities

10+

Languages in which services are delivered

12+

Active program areas, including legal education and clinics

THE GAP, IN NUMBERS

~1/2

Of Canadian adults face a serious civil or family legal problem within 3 years (CFC)

\$799M

Annual downstream cost to the state of unresolved legal problems (CFC)

\$72M→\$138M

Legal Aid Alberta expense growth, 2014 to 2024

~188

Matters per year diverted: the break-even on a \$300K investment

NOTEWORTHY

Government of Alberta Justice Award

Recognized for innovation in community justice delivery

Alberta Law Foundation

Partner in legal education and public legal information

Imagine Canada Accredited

National standards for governance and financial accountability

Omar Yaqub ICD.D DSL (Hon) MBA BSc

Servant of Servants, IslamicFamily

omary@islamicfamily.ca · +1.780.695.7477

IslamicFamily Hüb, 2-786, 10545 108 Street, Edmonton AB T5H 2Z8